

Social engagement has never been an obligation for me. It is a mindset shaped by personal experience. At the age of 15, a severe ski accident abruptly ended my career as an ambitious alpine racer, just one season before I was set to join the Styrian regional squad. Rather than stepping away from the sport entirely, I chose to give back: I started coaching children at Skiclub Rechberg and quickly realized that passion alone is not enough. Skiing is a cost-intensive sport. Between equipment, lift passes, transportation, and ongoing maintenance, the financial barrier is real and often insurmountable for many families. I began by lending my own gear to kids who couldn't afford it, organized group rides with my parents, and negotiated better collective discounts with the club board so that a lift ticket would no longer stand between a child and the slopes. These experiences fundamentally reshaped my understanding of social responsibility: it is not the grand gesture that changes communities, but the consistent, unglamorous work done day after day.

Over five years of active coaching, I built something I am genuinely proud of. Working alongside a team of two other certified coaches, we developed a structured youth training program within the club, growing the number of active participants from toddlers to teenagers by a factor of three and guiding around 130 young athletes along the way. Several of those kids went on to compete at regional level, and two former participants decided to become coaches themselves, continuing the cycle. Beyond the club, I collaborated with former teachers to organize the school team for the SNOWGames, a cross-school ski competition that has since become a permanent fixture in the school's annual calendar. What became increasingly clear throughout all of this is that organizing events and programs of this scale demands a significant investment of time. Time that, without financial support, I would have no choice but to redirect toward a part-time job.

That is precisely why this scholarship means more to me than financial relief. It is the foundation that would allow me to fully commit to what I have set out to do. At the Frankfurt School, I am planning to co-found the FS Ski Initiative together with a fellow student, a student-run community that gives people of all skill levels access to skiing, with a deliberate focus on those who would otherwise not find their way onto the slopes. From beginner day trips to a competitive racing group for more experienced skiers, the goal is to build something that captures the spirit of club sport and brings it into university life. The scholarship would allow me to dedicate myself entirely to both my studies and this initiative from day one, rather than splitting my energy across multiple obligations. It would also support the completion of my formal ski trainer certification, enabling me to offer an even higher standard of coaching to the young athletes I work with.

Skiing connects people, creates joy, and builds community. I want to carry exactly that spirit into the Frankfurt School and beyond.

Mit freundlichen Grüßen

Jakob Schinnerl